Workshop plan

General information

Purpose. The workshop aims to elicit students' and student advisors' perspectives on the acceptable design and use of predictive models for targeted student counseling. Through structured deliberation, participants reflect on key trade-offs related to data use, explainability, fairness, model performance, and conditions for outreach and support, with the goal of informing a stakeholder-grounded model configuration.

Participants. Three student advisors and around nine students, at three to four tables, each with one student advisor and three students.

Length. 2 hours 45 minutes, including a 15-minute break.

Plan and timeline

Section	Minutes	Cumulative time
Introduction and framing	15	0:15
Baseline survey	20–25	0:35–0:40
Survey-anchored table discussions	15–20	0:50–1:00
Survey-anchored plenary discussion	30	1:20–1:30
Break	15	1:35–1:45
Exploratory discussion: broader considerations	20–30	1:55–2:15
Endline survey	15	2:10–2:30
Final assessment (including preparation)	15	2:25–2:45
Closing and thanks	1	
Total	2h20–2h50	

1. Welcome and framing (15 minutes)

- Hand out name tags.
- Introduction and welcome presentation:
  - Key framing:
    - Overall aim: reach out to students experiencing academic difficulties.
      - The model could become relevant for any student.
      - Participants also consider experiences in their role more generally, such as those of peers and colleagues.
    - A data-based system may improve on the current one.
      - This raises questions and trade-offs, mainly between privacy and accuracy and between explainability and accuracy.
  - The goal of the workshop is to explore under what conditions, if any, the model would be acceptable and how those conditions could be reflected in system design.
  - Ground rules.
  - Workshop timeline.

2. Baseline survey (20–25 minutes)

- Write an overview of the survey on the whiteboard, including which group discusses which questions:

  - Q1, Q2: introduction
  - Q3: data and privacy (group 1)
  - Q4: explainability (group 2)
  - Q5: fairness (group 3)
  - Q6, Q7: intervention (all groups)
  - Q8, Q9: two general questions about the survey
- The survey focuses on the model:
  - Data privacy vs. accuracy
  - Explainability vs. accuracy
  - Fairness metric preference
  - Fairness vs. accuracy
  - Model optimization (precision vs. recall)
  - Intervention
- The first survey includes space for notes and reflections, and participants are encouraged to write them.

3. Survey-anchored table discussions, worksheet-based (15–20 minutes)

Participants discuss:

1. Which questions were unclear or hard to answer
2. Which questions are most important for how the model should be designed

Nominal group technique:

1. Participants reflect individually, with printed surveys available, and write down thoughts on the two questions above.
2. Each participant presents their reflections on the two questions, without debate.
3. The group discusses the questions, working with the worksheet and prioritizing the most important ones.

After data analysis, tables discuss the questions where their answers differed the most:

- How did you interpret the question?
- What did you answer, and why?
- If no one represents other opinions, why might someone think differently?

4. Survey-anchored plenary discussion (30 minutes)

- A spokesperson from each table shares key insights from the worksheet with the full group. At least one student and one advisor speak per table.
- As tables report, the facilitator synthesizes emerging themes using affinity mapping to visualize common concerns and areas of disagreement. Ideas that fall outside the survey framework are captured in a parking lot and may be brought forward in the open discussion phase.
- Following the table reports, structured dialogue explores the identified themes more deeply.
- The facilitator also asks whether the order of the data categories makes sense.
- Goals:
  - Build collective understanding across tables
  - Examine whether tensions can be resolved through solutions outside the model itself (e.g., opt-out mechanisms)
  - Generate creative solutions to tensions that the original survey options may not have anticipated
  - Identify both consensus areas and persistent disagreements that reflect genuine value conflicts

5. Break (15 minutes)

6. Exploratory discussion: broader considerations in plenary (20–30 minutes)

Open discussion, clearly framed as exploratory and not constrained by the survey. The focus is:

- What concerns, questions, or ideas do you have that the survey did not capture?
- Is the goal itself (identifying and reaching out to students experiencing academic difficulties using a predictive model) the right approach?

Using the 1-2-4-All technique (individual reflection, pairs, fours, then plenary), participants are invited to surface concerns, questions, and ideas that go beyond what the survey could capture. The facilitator acts as technology steward, mediating between technical possibilities and stakeholder concerns.

If there is time after discussing what participants brought, additional prompts may include:

- Whether outreach strategies or support should differ across stages of enrollment, or between students considering a program change and those leaving the university entirely
- What important concerns were not captured in the survey
- When such systems feel more or less acceptable regardless of their predictive performance
- Institutional and cultural variation, including different dropout cultures across faculties and programs, and how this should shape system design
- Whether a lower-resource, more automated variant could be acceptable, and under what conditions

There is no attempt to converge or resolve disagreement. All positions are legitimate.

7. Endline survey (15 minutes)

The same survey as at baseline.

8. Short break while the specification is prepared and distributed (5 minutes)

9. Final individual assessment (10 minutes)

Participants are shown a provisional model specification that reflects the middle ground responses from the endline survey across key dimensions (e.g., data use, explainability, fairness, outreach strategy).

It is emphasized that:

- This specification represents a majority-supported scenario, not a final or binding decision.
- The purpose is to understand individual reactions, reservations, and objections.
- All positions, including disagreement, are legitimate and important.

Participants then complete anonymous final assessment cards, providing their individual evaluation of this majority-supported scenario, and briefly justify their choice in writing. The assessment can be completed during the workshop or asynchronously afterward. It is in `acceptability_assessment.pdf`.

10. Closing and thanks (1 minute)